

Set Your Sights on Them

Domain suppliers

www.Directi.com

Offers domains for Rs 575. The site is also credited with having a standardised process for domain registration.

www.Vsplash.com

This domain name provider facilitates domain registration at prices ranging from Rs 399 to Rs 599.

www.Net4domains.com

Offers domains for Rs 525. The site also provides banner exchanges, business services, hosting, corporate mailing, etc.

www.123domainregistry.com

Offers real-time domain registration services for Rs 425 with 5 MB of free Web space.

www.register.com

Offers domain name registration online for prices ranging from \$35 to \$299.

http://domain.ncst.ernet.in

For registering India-specific domain names ending with .co.in

International domain name registrars

www.domain-supplier.com, www.domain-namesco.com, www.webdeveloper.com, www.netcolony.com, www.getyourdomain.com

Site builders

www.geocities.com

Log on and surf through the instructions for building your dream Web site. If you seek a domain name from geocities.com,

you'll get it as www.geocities.

com/myname. Geocities assists you through the entire process, right from creating your title and page designs (with page builders and page wizards) to uploading your site through a file manager.

www.tripod.com

Tripod provides 50 MB of free space and has introduced new multimedia add-ons to enhance the interactivity of your site.

www.homestead.com

This is a very user-friendly site builder with easy tools and a site building software that can be downloaded and used for designing your Web pages and then uploading them.

Location, location, location!

On the Internet your Web site address becomes your identity. You can choose to use the URL (Universal Resource Locator) provided to you by your Web host, which might go like www.serviceprovider.com/yourname. But if you are looking for a unique identity then your first move should be to register your own domain name.

There are several sites that offer these services, allowing you to register either online with an international credit card or via a longer paper-driven application process which allows you to pay by cheque or demand draft.

You would have to cough up anywhere between Rs 500 and Rs 1,000 to get your domain name registered. You need to first make sure that the name you have in mind has not already been taken. Most of these sites (like www.register.com) provide a search facility that helps you to settle on a unique name for your cyber abode. Simply hook on to the site and enter the domain name you want in the search box to check if it is available.

"When we were looking to register our domain, we found a plethora of tempting offers from various sites. We finally zeroed in on net4domains, which registered our domain name for Rs 575 for a period of two years," says Anup Nair, who owns an e-consultancy site.

Where do I host it?

Once you've decided on your domain name you need to look for a place to host your site. This means getting hard disk space on a computer that is always connected to the Internet.

There are a plethora of sites such as geocities.com and homestead.com offering free Web space to users. These offer anything between 25 and 50 MB of free space. But you would do well to consult your friends and colleagues before you

make your choice—some of these free Web space providers can be quite unreliable and a lot of them have shut down services recently. You might end up staring at a blank page instead of your dream cyber abode.

"The netfirms subdomain account of one of my friends got permanently deleted when he did not access it for nearly two months because he had other urgent matters to attend to," says Anup.

Also, the free Web hosts might not be able to provide you with some of the features that are important for your site. "I purchased the domain name from net4domains.com and secured 25 MB of free Web space. However, they do not offer e-mail forwarding services for subdomain accounts and all mail needs to be forwarded to another e-mail address belonging to me. Besides, you can't upload any file bigger than 1 MB, which is a problem for me," says Anup.

If you don't want to avail of free Web space because of the uncertainties and the strings attached, you can buy server space from an Internet Service Provider. Net4domains has packages ranging from Rs 850 for a 2 MB student account for one year to an economy pack which costs Rs 5,500 for 15 MB annually. Hosting on a server located in another country (mostly the US and Canada) can cost less and is usually a more reliable solution due to the higher bandwidth availability in those countries.

Looking for an architect?

Now that you've got a name and place for your site, you can either outsource the entire development process to a professional Web developer or employ your musty gray cells to read up on the basics and then

